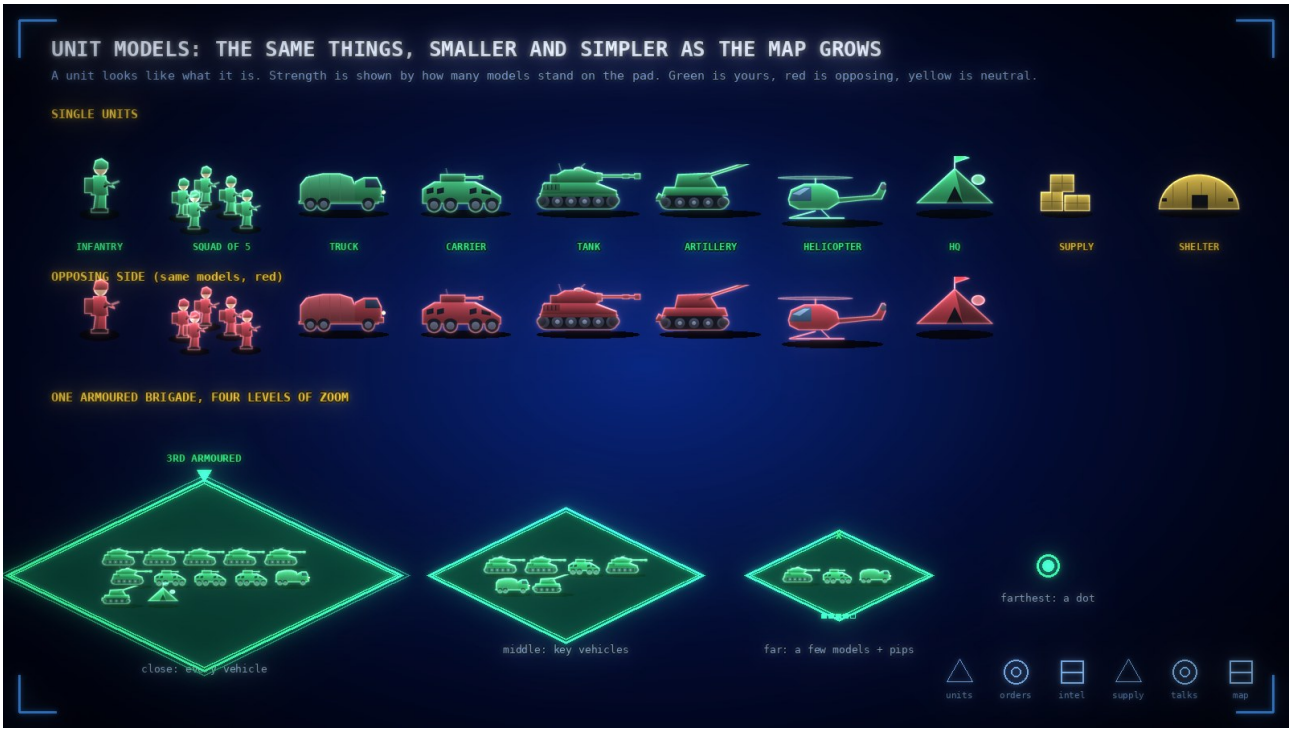
3D unit models, draft 2: real silhouettes

Thin Ice, look step 1: units that look like what they are, simpler as the map grows.

Summary. Following your feedback, the rectangle counters are replaced by small oblique 3D-looking models: a soldier and a squad of five, a canvas-covered truck, an eight-wheeled carrier, a tracked tank with road wheels, hull, turret and barrel, a self-propelled gun, a helicopter, an HQ tent, supply crates and a shelter. In draft 2 they are drawn as real silhouettes, not stacked boxes, so each reads as what it is even without context. On the map each group stands on a flat glowing pad in its team colour. **Strength is the number of models on the pad**, so a brigade that has lost half its vehicles shows half the models, with the missing ones outlined faintly. An echelon mark and five strength pips remain as a light overlay. Zooming out simplifies the group (every vehicle, then key vehicles, then three models plus pips, then a dot) without changing what it is. The green halo and double ring still mark ready and selected units. These are procedurally drawn mock-ups, not engine footage.



Model sheet. The single models in green (yours), red (opposing) and yellow (neutral), and one armoured brigade at four levels of zoom.



Act II, the border. A squad of five, a carrier platoon, a gun battery, a helicopter and an opposing tank platoon on terrain, with the selected platoon's movement outline, an artillery arc and an observation cone. Unseen enemies stay dashed '?' pads.



Act III, the Fulda Gap. Brigade-sized groups on the hex map: four tanks, a mechanised infantry group, a gun battery, an HQ, a depot. Contacts stay '?' until seen. An inset shows one brigade at three zoom levels.



Act IV, the threshold. Contamination zones, convoys of trucks, shelters, refugees as a crowd of small figures, a wreck, and battered brigades: the 3rd armoured has three of six vehicles left, the missing ones outlined. Strength is something you can see.

How the models are built (draft 2)

- Each model is a side-view silhouette built from real shapes (tracks with road wheels, sloped hull, rounded turret, long barrel with muzzle brake, cab with windscreen, canvas bed, rotor and tail boom) with a light gradient and a thin neon rim in its team colour.
- A model library gives one simple model per type, so new units are quick to add and every unit stays in the same style.
- Because the map only reads the unit's type, count and state, the models can be improved or replaced later without changing any rules.

Honest limits

- They are stylised silhouettes with a team-colour tint and a neon rim, drawn in code at high resolution and scaled down. They are recognisable at map size, but are not detailed vehicle art. A real artist could replace them later without changing anything else.
- The pads are drawn larger than the models for clarity. In the real game I would tune pad and model size to the map and zoom level.
- Each group is a still image here. Movement, fire and losses would animate the models.

Questions

- Do these models give the 'actual look' you wanted for Acts II to IV? Anything to change in shape, size or detail?
- Should the pad stay, or should models stand directly on the terrain with only a thin ring beneath them?
- Is 'strength equals number of models' right, or should a brigade always show a fixed number of models and use pips only?